向鸸鹋宣战

The Great Emu War



机枪为何没能解决鸸鹋危机?

READ 纯净阅读

CHECK 中文核对

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RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

Around Campion, Western Australia, most farmers were First World War veterans, settlers placed by a government scheme on marginal parcels of farmland. They were inexperienced growers, and a quarter had already quit. In 1932, after drought, roughly 20,000 emus swarmed in from arid country in flocks and trampled the wheat crops.

The farmers' plight took a military turn. In desperation, a delegation of ex-soldiers aired their grievances and asked the Defence Minister for machine-guns. He agreed, sending not a battalion but a detachment: Major Meredith, an artillery officer, with two soldiers, two Lewis guns, and 10,000 rounds of ammunition. The offensive began on 2 November 1932.

At a dam, about a thousand birds approached an ambush, but a gun jammed after a dozen fell. The flocks broke formation into small, agile groups, frustrating each tactical plan, and a truck-mounted gun proved futile. Six days of wasteful firing spent 2,500 rounds on perhaps 50 to 200 birds, a ludicrous return. After parliamentary questions and press ridicule, an embarrassing withdrawal came on 8 November, though shooting restarted within days.

Meredith was recalled on 10 December. His memo's inventory counted 986 kills from 9,860 rounds, a ratio of ten bullets to one bird. He likened the resilient birds' toughness to the armour of tanks. Five weeks of warfare had barely dented the hardy flocks' endurance.

Later pleas for reinforcements were refused, and intervention gave way to a bounty sanctioned by the government. This payout per bird gave farmers compensation and an incentive for extermination. Farmers claimed over 57,000 payments in six months of 1934, more than fifty-seven times Meredith's 986 kills.

中文译文

在西澳大利亚州坎皮恩一带，多数农民是第一次世界大战的退伍军人；政府通过一项安置计划，让这些定居者在一块块贫瘠农地上定居。他们缺少种植经验，已有四分之一放弃了耕作。1932年旱灾过后，约两万只鸸鹋从干旱地区成群涌入，践踏小麦庄稼。

农民的困境由此走向了军事解决。在绝望之中，一支由退伍士兵组成的代表团公开诉说不满，向国防部长请求机枪。部长答应了；派来的却不是一个营，而是一支小分队：炮兵军官梅雷迪思少校、两名士兵、两挺刘易斯机枪，以及一万发弹药。行动于1932年11月2日开始。

在一座水坝旁，约一千只鸸鹋接近伏击地点；但只打倒十来只，一挺机枪便卡了壳。鸟群散成灵活的小群，使一个个战术计划落空，卡车上架设的机枪也未能奏效。六天中低效的射击消耗了2500发子弹，可能只打死50至200只鸟，成效实在令人啼笑皆非。议会提出质询，报界加以嘲讽，部队于11月8日尴尬撤退，不过几天后便又恢复了射击。

梅雷迪思于12月10日被召回。他的备忘录列出的清单显示，9860发子弹打死986只鸟，相当于每只鸟耗费十发子弹。他把这些鸟顽强的抗击打能力比作坦克装甲。五个星期的战事，几乎没能削弱这些顽强鸟群的耐力。

此后，请求增援的恳求都遭到拒绝，军事干预让位于政府批准的悬赏制度。按每只鸟发放的赏金，既给农民提供了补偿，也成为扑杀鸸鹋的激励。1934年的六个月内，农民申领了五万七千多笔赏金，数量是梅雷迪思所报986只击杀数的五十七倍多。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

veteran n.
退伍军人
First World War veterans

marginal adj.
贫瘠的；不适宜耕作的
on marginal parcels of farmland.

arid adj.
干旱的
from arid country in flocks

plight n.
困境；苦境
farmers' plight

delegation n.
代表团
a delegation of ex-soldiers

grievance n.
不满；委屈
their grievances

detachment n.
小分队；分遣队
not a battalion but a detachment

ammunition n.
弹药
10,000 rounds of ammunition.

ambush n.
伏击；埋伏
approached an ambush

agile adj.
灵活的；敏捷的
small, agile groups

frustrate v.
使受挫；使落空
frustrating each tactical plan

futile adj.
徒劳的；无效的
proved futile.

ludicrous adj.
荒唐可笑的
a ludicrous return.

withdrawal n.
撤退；撤离
an embarrassing withdrawal

ratio n.
比例；比率
a ratio of ten bullets to one bird.

resilient adj.
顽强的；承受力强的
the resilient birds' toughness

reinforcement n.
增援部队；援兵
pleas for reinforcements

intervention n.
干预；介入
intervention gave way to a bounty

give way to phr. v.
让位于；被……取代
intervention gave way to a bounty

bounty n.
赏金；悬赏
a bounty sanctioned by the government.

compensation n.
补偿；赔偿
gave farmers compensation

incentive n.
激励；诱因
an incentive for extermination.

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共37项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

settler n.
定居者；移民

parcel n.
一块（土地）

farmland n.
农地

inexperienced adj.
缺乏经验的

grower n.
种植者

swarm v.
蜂拥而至

in flocks phr.
成群地（尤指鸟）

trample v.
践踏；踩坏

crop n.
庄稼；农作物

in desperation phr.
在绝望之中

air v.
公开表达

machine-gun n.
机枪

battalion n.
营（军队编制）

artillery n.
炮兵；火炮

offensive n.
进攻；攻势

jam v.
卡住；卡壳

formation n.
队形

tactical adj.
战术的

文中词汇与搭配 续

补充词汇共37项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

wasteful adj.
浪费的

parliamentary adj.
议会的

ridicule n.
嘲笑；嘲讽

embarrassing adj.
令人尴尬的

memo n.
备忘录

inventory n.
清单

bullet n.
子弹

liken v.
把……比作

toughness n.
坚韧；耐打程度

to prep.
与liken连用，表示比作

armour n.
装甲

warfare n.
战事；战争

hardy adj.
顽强的；耐受力强的

endurance n.
耐力；持久力

plea n.
恳求

sanction v.
批准；准许

payout n.
支付的款项

extermination n.
彻底消灭；扑灭

payment n.
支付款项

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 The farmers' _____ took a military turn.

02 After parliamentary questions and press ridicule, an embarrassing _____ came on 8 November, though shooting restarted within days.

03 His memo's inventory counted 986 kills from 9,860 rounds, a _____ of ten bullets to one bird.

04 Later pleas for _____ were refused, and intervention gave way to a bounty sanctioned by the government.

文章主线

- 困境 1932年旱灾后，约两万只鸸鹋涌入西澳农田、践踏庄稼，当地退伍军人农户向军方求助。
- 出兵 军方派一名少校和两名士兵，携两挺机枪、一万发子弹，试图控制鸟群。
- 受挫 鸟群分散成灵活小群，机枪卡壳，车载射击也无效，行动受到媒体和议会嘲讽。
- 撤军 部队一度撤离又复战，五周后被召回；报告称9860发子弹击杀986只，仍未解决鸟患。
- 转向 政府拒绝增援，改按只发赏金；1934年半年内农民申领逾5.7万笔，远超军方战果。

参考答案　1 plight 2 withdrawal 3 ratio 4 reinforcements